Digital Ethnography 16:920:571:01

Digital Ethnography

SOC 571

Fall 2024

Dr. Leslie Kay Jones

CLASS MISSION STATEMENT

The goal of this class is to acquaint graduate students with the methodology of digital ethnography. In addition to training students on how to perform this method, the syllabus addresses the history of this relatively new practice, its theoretical grounding, its strengths and weaknesses, and emergent intellectual perspectives. Sociology graduate students will emerge with a broad overview of the parameters of the method and think through potential critical interventions.

STUDENT OBJECTIVES

- Historicize digital ethnography within a longer tradition of ethnography.
- Develop a toolkit of digital ethnographic techniques.
- Identify and respond to the methodological demands of particular research inquiries.
- Weigh in on contemporary debates about ethnography as a sociological practice (as similar to or distinct from ethnography in other disciplines).
- Become familiar with major peer-reviewed publications in the field as well as standards for submission to those publications.
- Identify foundational theoretical assumptions in digital ethnography as a methodological field.
- Describe the possibilities and limitations of digital ethnography.
- Identify and choose between methodological supplements to digital ethnography in order to facilitate a mixed methods approach where necessary to appropriately address a research question.

ACCESSIBILITY

If you have any specific personal and/or academic accessibility requirements (learning disability, physical disability, language comprehension, etc.), I welcome you to speak with me or email me to let me know how to best accommodate your needs, especially if you don't have an apparent disability, have ongoing health issues or are trying to pass. You are NOT obligated to disclose any of these issues with me, only specify if there's any accommodations required. It is my pleasure to ensure that as my class meets the needs of all my students. If you need any adaptations for course materials (large font, pacing, image

description, closed captioning) let me know. You are also encouraged to register with the Office of Disability Support Services, but it is not a requirement.

GRADING STRUCTURE

20% - Class Memo

Each week, one or two students will be responsible for circulating a memo that synthesizes the week's literature and classroom conversation into a memo. The memo should summarize notable concepts and tensions while advancing an argument. Students who plan to publish research conducted in the class will have the option to submit an IRB proposal in lieu of 3 of the memos.

20% - Midterm course synthesis and evaluation

Students will write a 3-4 page response to class readings and discussions having taken place so far with an emphasis on themes that apply to their individual research projects.

20% - Final Paper Proposal with Preliminary Bibliography

40% - Final Paper 15 page paper

REQUIRED TEXTS

Daniels, J., & Gregory, K. (Eds.). (2016). *Digital sociologies*. Policy Press.

Taylor, T. V., Nardi, B., & Pearce, C. (2024). *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method, Updated Edition*. Princeton university press.

Whitehead, N. L., & Wesch, M. (Eds.). (2012). *Human no more: Digital subjectivities, unhuman subjects, and the end of anthropology*. University Press of Colorado.

SCHEDULE

Week 1: From Ethnography to Digital Ethnography

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). THREE BRIEF HISTORIES. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 13–28). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.6 (https://rutgers.instructure.com/courses/297729/files/42246050?wrap=1)

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). TEN MYTHS ABOUT ETHNOGRAPHY. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 29–51). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.7 (https://rutgers.instructure.com/courses/297729/files/42246051?wrap=1)

Duggan, M. (2017). Questioning “digital ethnography” in an era of ubiquitous computing. *Geography Compass*, *11*(5), e12313.

Forberg, P., & Schilt, K. (2023). What is ethnographic about digital ethnography? A sociological perspective. *Frontiers in Sociology*, *8*, 1156776

Paoli, A. D., & D’Auria, V. (2021). Digital ethnography: a systematic literature review. *Italian Sociological Review*, *11*(4S), 243-243.

Whitehead, N. L., & Wesch, M. (2012). Introduction: Human No More. In N. L. WHITEHEAD & M. WESCH (Eds.), *Human No More: Digital Subjectivities, Unhuman Subjects, and the End of Anthropology* (pp. 1–10). University Press of Colorado. http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.3

Week 2: The Sociology of Digital Ethnography

Selwyn, N., Nemorin, S., Bulfin, S., & Johnson, N. (2016). Toward a digital sociology of school. Digital sociologies, 147-162.

Lane, J., & Lingel, J. (2022). Digital ethnography for sociology: craft, rigor, and creativity. *Qualitative Sociology*, *45*(3), 319-326.

Cottom, T. M. (2016). Black cyberfeminism: Ways forward for intersectionality and digital sociology. Digital sociologies, 211-232.

Murthy, D. (2008). Digital ethnography: An examination of the use of new technologies for social research. *Sociology*, *42*(5), 837–855.

Fussey, P., & Roth, S. (2020). Digitizing Sociology: Continuity and Change in the Internet Era. *Sociology*, 54(4), 659-674. https://doi.org/10.1177/0038038520918562

Week 3: Identifying a Digital Fieldsite

Postill, J., & Pink, S. (2012, November). Social media ethnography: the digital researcher in a messy web. *Media International Australia incorporating Culture and Policy*, (145), 123+. **https://link-gale-com.proxy.libraries.rutgers.edu/apps/doc/A322564529/LitRC?u=new67449&sid=summon&xid=04c92324 (https://link-gale-com.proxy.libraries.rutgers.edu/apps/doc/A322564529/LitRC?u=new67449&sid=summon&xid=04c92324)**

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). HUMAN SUBJECTS CLEARANCE AND INSTITUTIONAL REVIEW BOARDS. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 151–158). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.13

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). RESEARCH DESIGN AND PREPARATION. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 52–64). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.8

Week 4: Digital participant observation/immersion

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). PARTICIPANT OBSERVATION IN VIRTUAL WORLDS. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 65–91). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.9

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). INTERVIEWS AND VIRTUAL WORLDS RESEARCH. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 92–112).

Princeton University Press. **https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.10 (https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.10)**

Cool, J. (2012). The Mutual Co-Construction of Online and Onground in Cyborganic: Making an Ethnography of Networked Social Media Speak to Challenges of the Posthuman. In N. L. WHITEHEAD & M. WESCH (Eds.), *Human No More: Digital Subjectivities, Unhuman Subjects, and the End of Anthropology* (pp. 11–32). University Press of Colorado. http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.4

Williams, A. (2016). On Thursdays we watch scandal: Communal viewing and Black Twitter. *Digital Sociologies*, 273-293.

Tripodi, F. (2016). Yakking about college life: Examining the role of anonymous forums on community identity formation. *Digital Sociologies*.

Week 5: Digital Participant Observation/Immersion Continued

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). OTHER DATA COLLECTION METHODS FOR VIRTUAL WORLDS RESEARCH. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 113–128). Princeton University Press. **https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.11 (https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.11)**

Pink, S., Horst, H., Lewis, T., Hjorth, L., & Postill, J. (2015). Digital ethnography: Principles and practice.

Week 6: Theorizing the Digital

Daniels, J. (2017). Bodies in code. *Digital Sociologies*, 335-338.

Haber, B. (2017). Queer Facebook? Digital sociality and queer theory. *Digital sociologies*, 387-399.

Heckenberger, M. (2012). Marginal Bodies, Altered States, and Subhumans: (Dis)Articulations between Physical and Virtual Realities in Centro, São Paulo. In N. L. WHITEHEAD & M. WESCH (Eds.), *Human No More: Digital Subjectivities, Unhuman Subjects, and the End of Anthropology* (pp. 199–216). University Press of Colorado. **http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.14 (http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.14)**

Tufekci, Z. (2012). We Were Always Human. In N. L. WHITEHEAD & M. WESCH (Eds.), *Human No More: Digital Subjectivities, Unhuman Subjects, and the End of Anthropology* (pp. 33–48). University Press of Colorado. **http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.5 (http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.5)**

Week 7: Discourse Analysis

Brock, A. (2018). Critical technocultural discourse analysis. *New Media & Society*, *20*(3), 1012-1030.

KhosraviNik, M. (2014). Critical discourse analysis, power, and new media (digital) discourse. *Why discourse matters: Negotiating identity in the mediatized world*, 283-301.

Digital Discourse Analysis: Finding Meaning In Small Online Spaces ~ Timothy Recuber;

Interactivity, Social Media, and Superman: How Comic Books Can Help Us Understand And Conceptualise Interactivity Online ~ Harry T. Dyer

Johnstone, B. (2018). *Discourse analysis*. John Wiley & Sons, Incorporated. Chapter 1

Recuber, T. (2017). Digital discourse analysis: Finding meaning in small online spaces. *Digital sociologies*, 47-60.

Karlsson, M. (2018). Content analysis and online news: epistemologies of analysing the ephemeral Web. In *Rethinking Research Methods in an Age of Digital Journalism* (pp. 177-192). Routledge.

Week 8: Negotiating the Idiosyncrasies of Digital Fieldwork

Abidin, C. (2020). Somewhere between here and there: Negotiating researcher visibility in a digital ethnography of the influencer industry. *Journal of Digital Social Research*.

Sumiala, J., & Tikka, M. (2020). Digital media ethnographers on the move–An unexpected proposal. *Journal of Digital Social Research*, *2*(1), 39-55.

Wesch, M., & the Digital Ethnography Class of Spring 2009. (2012). Anonymous, Anonymity, and the End(s) of Identity and Groups Online: Lessons from the "First Internet-Based Superconsciousness." In N. L. WHITEHEAD & M. WESCH (Eds.), *Human No More: Digital Subjectivities, Unhuman Subjects, and the End of Anthropology* (pp. 89–104). University Press of Colorado. http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.8

Week 9: Digital Interviewing and Other Components of Digital Ethnography

Käihkö, I. (2020). Conflict chatnography: Instant messaging apps, social media and conflict ethnography in Ukraine. *Ethnography*, *21*(1), 71-91.

Beaulieu, A. and Simakova, E. 2006, 'Textured Connectivity: An Ethnographic Approach to Understanding the Timescape of Hyperlinks', *Cybermetrics*, vol. 10, no. 1, http://cybermetrics.**cindoc.csic.es/articles/v10i1p5.html (http://cindoc.csic.es/articles/v10i1p5.html)** .

Joanna Neil. (2017). Digital Auto-Ethnography Interview with Self. *PRISM Blackburn*, *1*(1), 46–72. https://doi.org/10.24377/LJMU.prism.vol1iss1article299

Week 10: New Media Ecosystem

Caliandro, A. (2018). Digital methods for ethnography: Analytical concepts for ethnographers exploring social media environments. *Journal of contemporary ethnography*, *47*(5), 551-578.

Personal Data Practices in the Age of Lively Data ~ Deborah Lupton

Gajjala, R., & McComas, S. E. (2012). Splitting and Layering at the Interface: Mediating Indian Diasporas across Generations. In N. L. WHITEHEAD & M. WESCH (Eds.), *Human No More: Digital Subjectivities, Unhuman Subjects, and the End of Anthropology* (pp. 105–130). University Press of Colorado. **http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.9 (http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt4cgr5j.9)**

Lundström, M., & Lundström, T. P. (2021). Podcast ethnography. *International Journal of Social Research Methodology*, *24*(3), 289-299.

Week 11: Problematizing Digital Ethnography

Barnes, N., & Hames, S. (2023). Centralising Qualitative Research in Big Data Methods Through Algorithmic Ethnography. *Journal of Digital Social Research*, *5*(1), 90-108.

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). CONCLUSION: ARRIVALS AND NEW DEPARTURES. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 196–200). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.16

De Seta, G. (2020). Three lies of digital ethnography.

Week 12: Ethics

Mayne, A. (2017). Virtually ethical: Ethnographic challenges in researching textile crafters online. Digital sociologies, 59-74.

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). ETHICS. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method* (pp. 129–150). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.12

BOELLSTORFF, T., NARDI, B., PEARCE, C., & TAYLOR, T. L. (2012). WRITING UP, PRESENTING, AND PUBLISHING ETHNOGRAPHIC RESEARCH. In *Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of*

Method (pp. 182–195). Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.15 (https://doi.org/10.2307/j.cttq9s20.15)

Cera, M. (2023). Digital ethnography: ethics through the case of QAnon. *Frontiers in Sociology*, *8*, 1119531.

Sveningsson Elm, M. (2009). How do various notions of privacy influence decisions in qualitative Internet research? In A. N. Markham & N. K. Baym (Eds.), *Internet inquiry: Conversations about method* (pp. 69–87). Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications.

Week 13: Model Work

Jones, L. K. (2020). # BlackLivesMatter: An analysis of the movement as social drama. *Humanity & Society*, *44*(1), 92-110.

Tripodi, F. B. (2022). *The propagandists' playbook: How conservative elites manipulate search and threaten democracy*. Yale University Press.

Week 14: Model Work

Course Summary:

Date	Details	Due
Mon Nov 4, 2024	Final Paper Proposal (https://rutgers.instructure.com/courses/297729/assignments/3389120)	due by 11:59pm
Fri Dec 6, 2024	Final Paper (https://rutgers.instructure.com/courses/297729/assignments/3424706)	due by 11:59pm